Institute for Defence Studies and Analyses (IDSA), began framing policy discourse on Afghanistan. In popular Indian television and print media too Afghanistan gained salience in the wake of attacks on Indians in Afghanistan. From the intelligence community, in addition to the R&AW, the military intelligence also played a role on the ground after 2002.[38] The political compromise at Bonn, and the partisans' reluctant acceptance of Karzai as president, was a low cost to pay for what India was getting in return, which was a promise to reengage with Afghanistan and to rebuild its lost economic and cultural presence in that country. As Mukhopadhaya put it, 'there was a universal welcome to the return of the international community in Afghanistan', and India would not be left behind.[39] However, the question of how these seemingly benign projects would enhance India's political and strategic presence in Afghanistan persisted.

An interesting example of India's use of its aid for political purposes was indicated by the scholarship programme it ran in Afghanistan. Directly under the Indian Council for Cultural Relations (ICCR), these scholarships were used to coopt provincial Afghan politicians.[40] Barring the airfare, the scholarships covered full tuition fees, accommodation, and even offered a limited living allowance, making it a highly attractive deal for Afghan students.[41] The catch however was that Indian consulate officials could decide who to offer these scholarships based on independent political judgment, in consultation with the Afghan Ministry of Higher Education and local power brokers. As a result, whomever the local Afghan politician or strongman would recommend, would be offered the scholarship. It was a classic case of building micro-dependencies wherein Afghan politicians would build a reputation of 'helping' their constituents by facilitating education and stay in India. In return, the politician would develop a vested interest in securing Indian presence in the region and ensuring safety of Indian personnel. Mukhopadhaya and Saran argue that these projects had tremendous appeal among Afghans, and that building goodwill in Afghanistan was 'a great deal' in itself.[42] True, unlike Western aid projects that alluded towards developing the Afghan state and lead towards nation building, Indian projects were limited in ambition and investment, but high on visibility. Yet, Afghan responses were mixed.